

SHOW OF SUPPORT
CM Siddaramaiah and deputy D.K. Shivakumar at the Congress MLAs' meeting in Bengaluru, Aug. 22

KARNATAKA

SIDDA IN A LAND TUSSLE

part of a land parcel notified for acquisition by MUDA in 1992 to create a housing layout. The plot in question was, however, denotified for acquisition six years later. In 2004, the plot was purchased by Parvathi's brother B.M. Mallikarjunaswamy, who gifted it to her in 2010. Siddaramaiah has argued that his wife had petitioned MUDA after finding that the authority had encroached on her property to form the current housing layout. In 2021, when a BJP regime was in power in Karnataka, a decision was taken—as per a compensation scheme—to award 14 sites to her.

While the Opposition claims there were irregularities at every step, the CM says the allegations are aimed at tarnishing his four-decade-old 'blemish-free' political career. On August 22, the CM convened a Congress legislature party meeting in Bengaluru to rally support from party MLAs before he and deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar flew to Delhi to apprise the party high command of the developments. Speaking after their meeting on August 23, Congress general secretary Randeep Surjewala claimed there was a "systematic assault" through the office of "a puppet governor" by the BJP and JD(S) to "destabilise" an elected government. "This is also an assault on a backward class CM who is now the seniormost chief minister in the country," says Surjewala.

The Siddaramaiah government is also trying to pay the Opposition back in the same coin. On August 22, the council of ministers decided to provide 'aid and advice' to the governor on similar petitions seeking sanction against Opposition party members that have been pending. Law minister H.K. Patil says there are four major petitions pertaining to Sections 17A and 19 of the Prevention of Corruption Act pending before Gehlot. These include an application by the Lokayukta in November 2023 seeking sanction to file a chargesheet against JD(S) leader and Union minister H.D. Kumaraswamy in a corruption case related to the grant of a mining lease to a firm, Shree Sai Venkateshwara Minerals, dating back to the latter's first stint as CM in 2007. Besides this, there are pending petitions for sanction against BJP legislators Shashikala Jolle, G. Janardhana Reddy and former MLA Murugesh Nirani. While the first one dates back to December 2021, the other two pertain to May and February 2024, respectively.

Kumaraswamy has responded, alleging he was being targeted for exposing the government's alleged scams. In a press conference on August 21, he argued that the Congress was pursuing a "dead case". "How long does it take for the (Lokayukta) special investigating team to investigate?" Kumaraswamy asked, adding that there was a Supreme Court direction from 2016 to complete the probe in three months. Denying the charge of political vendetta, Patil maintains that the cabinet's move was to ensure action was taken in cases where investigations had taken place. "In Siddaramaiah's case, it was a private complaint and no investigation has taken place. There is a big difference," he said at a briefing. As Karnataka's politics hots up, more skirmishes are in the offing. ■

PLOT TWISTS

- **Governor sanctions probe into MUDA site allotments to Siddaramaiah's wife Parvathi**
- **Sidda moves HC to get order revoked, alleges a BJP-JD(S) conspiracy to malign him**
- **In tit-for-tat move, law minister seeks sanction on petitions pending against Opposition members, including former chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy**